Multiple crises subsequently wreaked havoc in Indo-Pakistani relations since their mutual acquisition of nuclear weapons especially in 1999 and 2001–2002. [19] But despite intense tensions, none of these crises have culminated in full-scale war. Decision makers in both countries have steadily and increasingly realized that the initiation of a major conventional conflict could, under a number of possible scenarios, tempt one side to consider the use of nuclear weapons. Consequently, both sides have exhibited considerable restraint and have chosen to eschew horizontal escalation and not to violate certain tacit thresholds.

Since the outbreak of the Kargil war, Indian military strategists have been struggling to forge a military doctrine and the requisite capabilities that might enable them to respond to future Pakistani provocation without triggering an escalation to full-scale war. It is far from clear that they will be able to formulate a viable doctrine that could effectively contain the possibilities of an escalatory spiral following the initiation of even limited attacks on Pakistani territory.[20] On the other hand, while Pakistan may deem the risks of abetting terror in India both controllable and calculable, it will also be loath to initiate a significant conventional conflict with India. Initiating a conventional conflict of such magnitude could invite substantial Indian retaliation and might push the two states toward a nuclear conflict.[21] Pakistan's decision makers may well be risk-prone; however, in their long history of conflict with India they have not engaged in fundamentally irrational behavior. They have been guilty of flawed judgment, have taken refuge in "false optimism," and have displayed strategic myopia.[22] None of these behavioral traits, however, are unique to Pakistani military and civilian officials.

Furthermore, there is evidence that the politico-military leadership does recognize the significance of the nuclear revolution and the unique properties of nuclear weapons.[23] Consequently, they are likely to see their nuclear capabilities as a viable deterrent against India's present and future conventional superiority. Barring a complete breakdown of the Pakistani state there is little reason to believe that nuclear deterrence will not remain robust in this bilateral relationship and help avert a full-scale war.